

sensation as your vagina becomes fully stretched. Your doctor may tell you to stop pushing at this point so that your perineum can thin further and so that the baby's head isn't delivered too suddenly, which could cause serious tears. She may tell you to pant or blow instead to help you resist the urge to bear down.

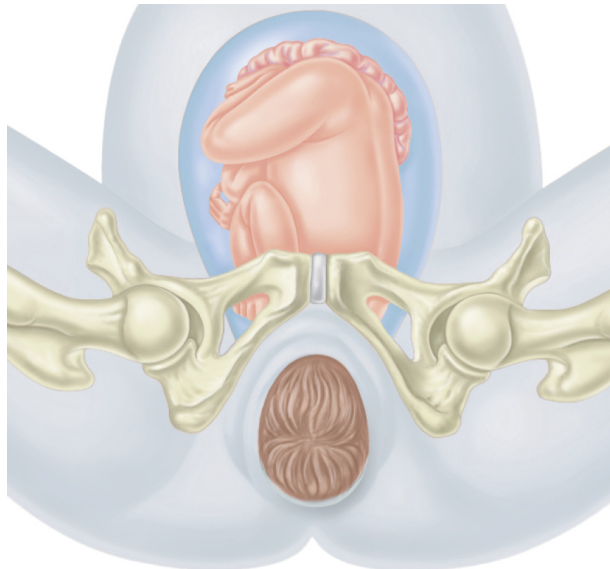
Crowning Initially, the head will descend with each contraction and then move slightly back up the birth canal. Eventually, it will descend far enough to be visible through the vagina at the height of a contraction, known as “crowning,” before it once again moves back up and disappears. As contractions continue, the head will finally stay in the vaginal opening and will not slip back at the end of the contraction — this stage is known as crowning.

As your baby descends, the chin will be tucked down toward the chest and the head will rotate slightly so that your baby is facing your back; this enables the largest part of your baby's head to pass through the widest part of the pelvis. As the head passes out of the vagina, it extends backward so that it almost touches his or her back. The doctor will check whether the cord is around the baby's neck. If this is the case, it will be lifted up and away from the neck. The doctor will remove any mucus from your baby's nose and mouth. Once the head has been delivered, it will return to its normal position.

Rest of the body After the delivery of the head, your baby will turn slightly so that the first shoulder can be delivered. Your doctor may help by applying gentle traction to your baby's head at the side to help the first shoulder emerge. Once the first shoulder has been delivered, your baby will turn again slightly so that the second shoulder can be delivered. After this, the rest of the body will slip out and the delivery of your baby will be complete.

Monitoring you and your baby

In the second stage, the baby's heartbeat and your contractions are monitored. If the second stage is drawing out, and you become tired from pushing, an assisted delivery may be suggested with [forceps](#) or [vacuum](#).



The crowning of the head means that the delivery of your baby is imminent and within one or two contractions the head will emerge.